SURREALISM AS AN ESCAPE

escape

Verb

ɪˈskeɪp

to get free from something, or to avoid something

For the theme of escape I felt surrealism is the most appropriate style as it allows for expression of what happens in an artist's unconscious mind. Surrealism was a cultural movement in the 20th century in which images and events were put together illogically like one experiences in a dream. For my comparative study I chose the artists, Leonora Carrington, Thukral and Tagra, and Ignasi Monreal, who used surreal art to express their escape from their personal experiences, the escape of people around them, and the escape to a hallucination for Gucci's Spring Summer 2018 advertisement campaign. The three artists have been brought up in different cultures in England, North India, and Spain during various time periods.



Dominus Aeris Escape 5
Thukral and Tagra
Dimensions: 182 × 182 × 5 cm
Medium: Oil on canvas
Created: 2012

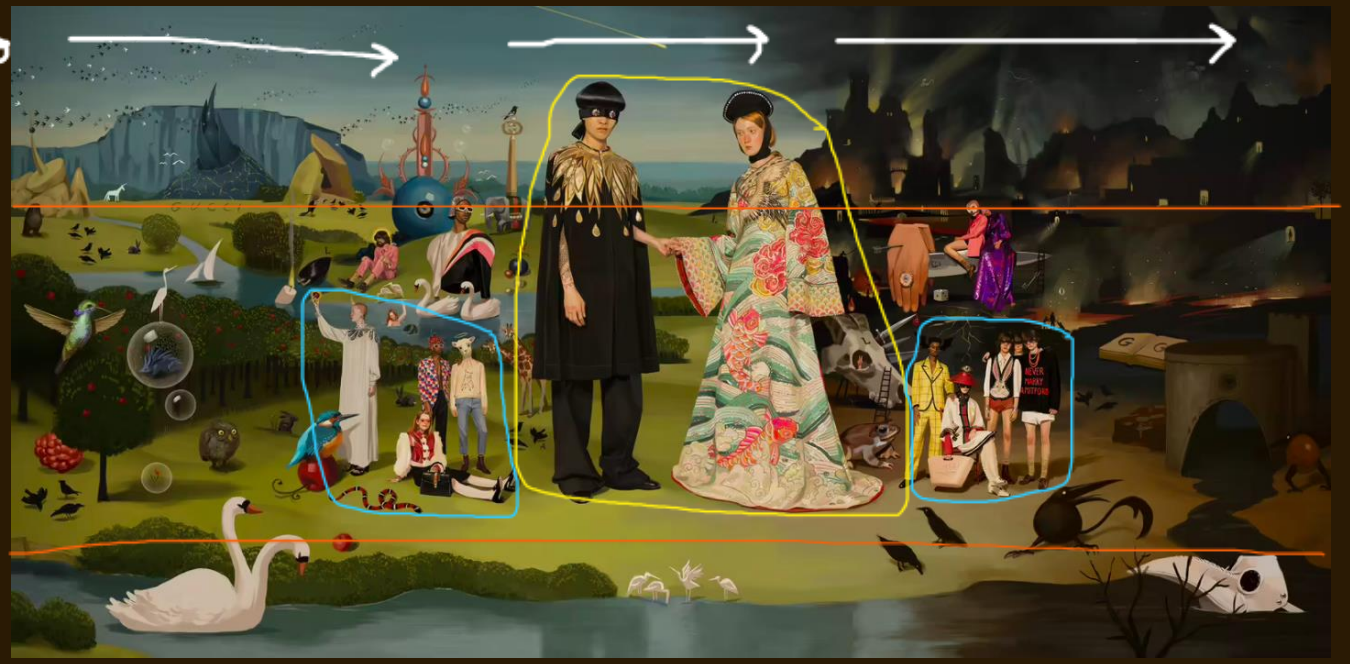


Green Tea
Leonora Carrington
Dimensions: 61 × 76.2 cm
Medium: Oil on canvas
Created: 1942



SS18 'Hallucination' inspired by 'The Garden Of Earthly Delights' (1490-1500) by Hieronymus Bosch Held and 'The Arnolfini Portrait' (1434) by Jan Van Eyck
Ignasi Monreal
Dimensions: Medium: Digital art Created: 2018

Formal Analysis of '***SS18 'hallucination''*** – Ignasi Monreal's take on the Garden of Earthly Delights



Composition

Inspired by 'The Garden of Earthly Delights' by Hieronymus Bosch, this painting tells a story through a chronological flow of scenes from left to right. There are two main subjects in the centre of the painting. We can see the painting divided into layers horizontally as well through the use of water, land, and sky and the layers together create depth. The composition can be described as varied due to multiple figures of sizes that are disproportionally smaller than the subject which further emphasises the male and female figures as the main subject of the painting. This use of abnormal proportions brings out the surrealism of the piece. We also see this in kingfishers, owls, giraffes, fruits, swans, and frogs that are almost the same size as the small human figures.
The smaller figures and elements dispersed around the background of the painting create a sense of imbalance and chaos. The presence of very little negative spaces allows the viewer to get a peek into the maximalist style of Ignasi Monreal. The combination of the lake, dark right side, sky, and patch of trees on the left creates a vignette.
Due to the scale of this work, the ratio between its length and breadth along with its horizontally oriented composition contribute to a sense of vastness to create a landscape. Upon closer look, we can see how the small details also are used to bring out Gucci's theme by using icons often found on Gucci apparel and advertisements. Yet, we can also see a slight symmetry in the way the artist has used clusters of small elements such as the trees and the flying birds on the left to balance out the cluster of the dark structures on the right. The use of circular objects on the left is contrasted using geometric triangular and rectangular shapes that are resembled on the right.



There is a sense of importance given to the two headed swan in the water body as it swims in the left half in isolation and is balanced by a white skull of a bird on the right.

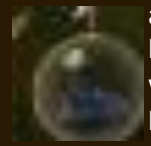


Light

Due to the gradient in the sky, and the overall use of dusky values, the scene does not seem to be illuminated by intense sunlight but instead a warmer evening remnant of light after sunset through which the artist has captured the mood of the scene. This gives a feel of mystery due to the connotation of twilight. The use of light here creates a middle path between the lighter left and darker right side of the image. The two sources of light in this artwork are the natural light contributed by the sun, that seems to be radiating from the point of view of the audience, and artificial light present in the dark structures on the right. We can also see the artist's attention to detail through the reflection of the light from the sun in the bubbles as well. Thus, the use of light is effective in making the surrealistic landscape seem more believable; it creates a serene mood and a luring place to escape to along with a sense of mystery.

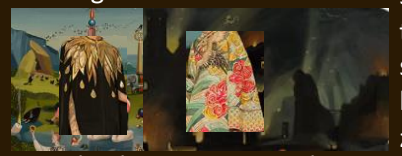






Colour

The overall colour palette is inspired by Gucci's brand campaign. The use of black attire on the left figure contrasts the light, colourful attire on the right figure. This use of contrasting attire contradicts the colour contrast in the background as the colourful part is the left and the right is black and dark with yellow accents.



This creates a yin and yang of Balance in the artwork. The composition has also been constructed around the analogous use of dull blue and green in the centre and left of the artwork that adds to the sombre dreaminess of the scene. The colours of the background also create an emphasis on the icons of Gucci's brand such as vibrant purple, white and yellow attire, animals and fruits. The interplay of brighter colours with sombre tones reminiscing the work of Heironymus Bosch forge the surrealism of the landscape due to the strangeness of the combination.

Medium and texture

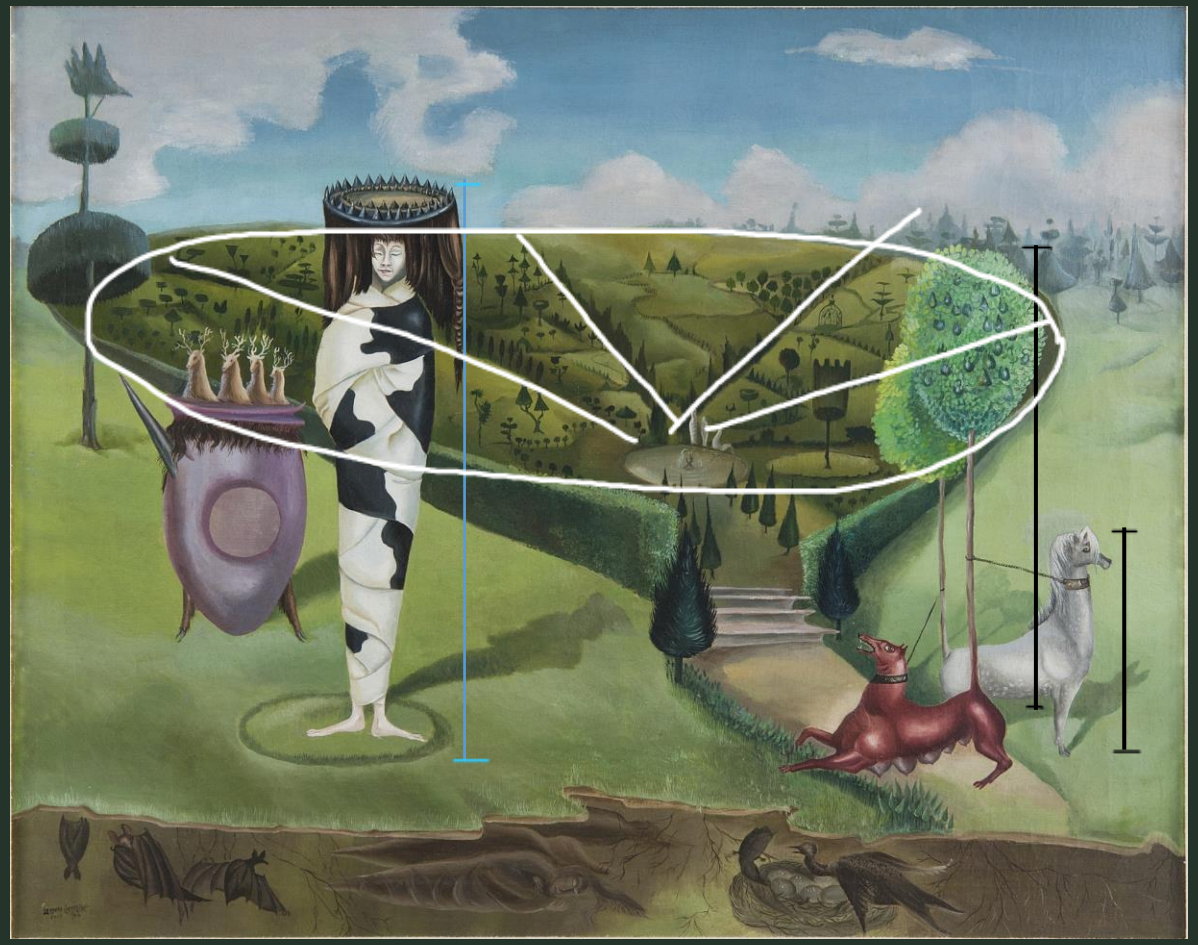
Due to the use of a digital medium, the artist can create multiple textures and styles. Overall, the piece looks smooth and has a realistic rendering of most elements. The artist has made a skilful use of blending tools to portray skin and fabric. In the trees and bushes, Ignasi Monreal uses pointillism to create a texture. We can see that there is a stark difference in the detail and the attention to textures in the figures and icons, and the greenery and nature. This is effective in emphasising the importance of the figures and icons as they are in line with Gucci's theme. It makes these elements stand out and therefore highlight the illogical contributions to the surrealistic style.



Form

This painting is also inspired by 'Arnolfini portrait' by Jan Van Eyck which can be seen in the two central figures. The forms show surrealism through the swan with two heads and only the top half of a person near the stream in the background. In the left of the background, on zooming in, a unicorn is visible which adds to the magical element in the artwork. There is an odd structure in the background which seems to be inspired by similar structures in 'The Garden of Earthly Delights' which is not identifiable and hence, this too adds to the surrealistic characteristic of the work.

Formal Analysis of ‘Green Tea’



Composition

This painting is of a panoramic view of two parallel universes that collide to present a dream-like surreality. In this painting, Leonora Carrington does not limit herself by strictly adhering to composition rules which allows her to explore and accommodate skewed and distorted landscapes. The uneven spacing and sizes of subjects provide imagery that portrays a reflection of the artist’s emotional devastation. The presence of multiple dimensions through the parallel worlds that collide hint at disorientation and absurdity. The landscape in the painting's centre appears to be created from an aerial perspective, and the plants appear to share this perspective. Despite sharing the same physical area as the backdrop, the foreground subjects are shown in a linear perspective, bringing the subjects closer to eye level. The self-contradictory viewpoints are a visual representation of irrationality and a deconstruction of reality. Carrington also used a variety of scales to achieve visual ridiculousness. The two horses appear to be being watched from afar, dwarfed by the human figure and the mauve egg. They are, however, placed closer to the front, as though they are not far away. Carrington's jumbled intellect and consciousness are depicted by the unexpected visual distortions. We can also see a radial pattern through the composition of the painting where the staircase can be seen as a central point that leads the viewer’s eye outwards continuing to the edge of the surface.

Light

The artist uses shadows in the same direction to show the single source of light – probably the sun as we can see through the warm atmosphere. She captures the light of the late afternoon on a clear day. Her use of dual universes is brought out through the contrast in the use of light in the lower section of the painting. The inner landscape in the centre of the painting is darker as well and creates a shadow effect which makes it seem to be on a level lower than the grass surrounding it. We can also see the sunlight brought out through the multiple shades of blue in the sky as it gradually transcends from lighter to darker.

Form

In this scenery we see different shapes of trees throughout. The large, textured trees in the foreground seem to have a long thin trunk with oval shape of the leaves and branches of the tree while the trees further away are more triangular and structured through the use of levels of the trees. This use of differently shaped trees subtly contributes to the surreality of the painting as it doesn’t immediately strike the viewer as something that is unreal. As the colour of the trees are fairly similar to ones we see in nature, through the forms given to them we find that they seem to be influenced by Leonora Carrington’s perceptions.

Texture and material

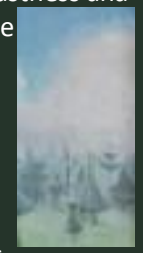
The artist makes a skilled use of oil paint to create a thick, opaque texture. With oil paint, she creates smoothens the texture of grass which brings out the surreality of this piece, giving it a sense of vastness. She also creates texture in the trees and shrubs in the foreground of the painting by showing visible brush strokes, small dots and lines which accentuate the texture of the flora around her, giving an insight into her mind.

Space and depth

This painting explores different universes using space and depth that create surrealism. This unnatural space and depth that ties together multiple distorted landscapes portrays the artist’s mind space in her asylum. Her depiction of the inner garden in the centre of the painting leads to an uncomfortable experience for the viewer as the stairs leading to the entrance of this garden seem to be going upwards even though the central garden has been painted from an aerial perspective, showing it to be on a lower level than the greenery that surrounds it. To the right of the painting, there are multiple trees that tend to decrease in size which show us the vastness and the extent of the landscape. The lower half of the painting also shows us a layer of a universe that seems to be under the gardens. We can see this dimension from a linear perspective which once again creates a shift in the audience’s understanding of where exactly they are viewing this landscape from as the painting overall seems to capture three different viewpoints.

Colour

The colours in the painting are muted and light. A lot of white is used where the clouds on the right meet the small trees far away which help build on the vastness and the perspective the artist tries to bring out. The white on the right also creates a dream like effect on the landscape and it has a heaven like connotation. The overall use of a cooler palette brings out a sense of serenity and calm which balances the distorted dimensions and dark imagery. The muted colours allow the painting to seem “normal” when viewed from a distance. Shades of blue in the sky, green in the nature and brown in the underground universe bring out the artist’s perception of the regular world around her that distorted itself in her mind. The four main subjects of the painting are brought out using reds, purples, black and white which emphasize these elements while staying within the style of lighter, muted, cooler colours.





Formal Analysis of 'Dominus Aeris Escape 5'

This painting is a piece from "Q." The exhibition continues with themes the artists have explored in previous bodies of work, namely the Indian Diaspora and its desire to "escape" from India. "Q" is the story of one of the many abandoned brides that haunt the state of Punjab, almost a contemporary fairy-tale fraught with loneliness, desperation and confusion, yet infused with hopeful dreams that are difficult to let go of.



Composition

This work of art has a chaotic composition of one main subject and then few chaotic imbalanced elements that ornament the main subject. The composition can be described as kinetic as the hot air balloons create an illusion of movement and wind which also carries the eyes of the audience in an upward direction yet, at the same time, the use of warmer colours in the hot air balloon causes them to become emphasized and hence they draw attention first. This creates a balance in which the viewer views the top half of the painting first and then views the bottom.

Colours

There is also a complementary contrast between the colours of the hot air balloon and the background which brings out the playfulness and the vibrancy of this piece. This style of composition brings about feelings of excitement and overwhelm as well as confusion in the audience due to the busy use of multiple subjects.

Space

The artists make an effective use of **the negative space** to emphasize the smaller subjects using lighter and warmer shades of blue to green behind them and the scale of the painting allows the artists to make a fair attempt at the finer detailing in smaller elements.

Icons

The house that seems to be inside the main hot air balloon resembles the fire that gives the hot air balloon its ability to fly which could be symbolic of the households and the families that support their children's dreams and are the reason that people are able to migrate to a different country.

The clothes hanging to dry are a common motif in the escape series, it is symbolic of mediocre Indian houses and the practices that are left behind in India when people migrate.

Shapes

The main **shapes** seen in the artwork are oval like which can also be seen in the patches of greenery coating the houses. The emphasis of this work is clearly on the hot air balloons that seem welcomed into this surrealistic floating Punjabi world created by the artists due to the Indian ideology of welcoming people with bright lights, colours and celebration which is shown through the ribbons, flags and buntings strung along with string lights.

Composition + icons

The composition uses string lights to maintain a sense of dimension and form by bringing out the curve of the hot air balloon, and it draws a slight line between the two parts of the work which are also shown through the active contrast of colours between the warm coloured hot air balloons and the greenery coated houses which could be symbolic of the way that the hot air balloons are coming from abroad and they carry the excitement that the people who believe that they live uneventful or unsuccessful lives await in their homes.

The cluster of the four smaller hot air balloons on the right side produce a sense of unity or community that indicate that all the hot air balloons seem to be coming together from one place to the floating Punjabi houses.

Form

The **form** in the painting has also been brought out with the effective use of the chiaroscuro technique. The form of the cluster of the 4 hot air balloons are warped and wavy which brings about a sense of windiness and lightness of the balloons. The two dimensional background in addition to the floating and oddly placed elements are what make the painting a surrealist one.

Colours

With the overall use of **lighter colours** and white highlights the artists have captured the effect of sunlight on the hot air balloons, houses and greenery. This sense of daylight creates a field of wellbeing, energy and brilliance. The chiaroscuro in the hot air balloons also reflects the smooth texture of the material of the balloon, and in the houses, it highlights the crispness of the edges.

Icons

The paper planes refer to a nostalgic mood or a sense of childlike playful imagination in the canvas. Thukral and Tagra are very fond of games and using games as a theme in most of their art, this is maintained in this creation with the use of the black and white checked flags which indicate the presence of a winner or a car reaching the finish line first.

Perspective

This painting seems to have a **fixed viewpoint** and a linear perspective which makes the audience feel equal or part of this world.

Conceptual and Contextual Analysis of '*SS18 'hallucination"* – Ignasi Monreal's take on the Garden of Earthly Delights





Ignasi Monreal is a multidisciplinary artist based in Rome who was born in Barcelona in 1990. Painting, design, creative direction, pottery, animation, and cinema are among his many mediums. He designed Gucci's Spring/Summer 2018 advertisement, which was the first of its type to be entirely digitally painted.

Gucci asked Monreal to reinterpret the House's motifs and items in his own manner and this artwork was his response amongst others. Since he was in charge of the House of Gucci's new digital project, Ignasi Monreal brought his own magical perspective to the recent advertising. This campaign was created without the use of photographs and instead utilised graphics by Monreal. The images transport us through three elements - the earth, the sea, and the sky, with no limitations of logic in illustrations. This work incorporates fantastical creatures from the Gucci runway onto one of the most famous Renaissance sets: Hieronymus Bosch's The Garden of Earthly Delights. Monreal's artwork for the advertisement urges us to escape to and explore the Gucci world.

"My mother used to tell me Greek myths instead of fairytales so I believe they shaped my view of the world. I like to use the principles of classicism so I can subvert it after." These words by Monreal give us an insight into his perspective as an artist. Providing context to his thought process, we can see how the influence of his mother's emphasis on Greek stories gave him an early understanding of classic artworks which he then used to subvert to fit into a modern context.

"I like creating things that you need to look twice and it's not self-evident immediately. But it should be truly democratic. I want to do pieces that my grandmother can understand as well." "I'm interested in art's timeless quality and its 'archaeological' significance for future generations, which is why I'm drawn to global symbolism and realism, which is a language that everybody can comprehend." Fulfilling the purpose of this artwork – promoting Gucci's brand – while expressing his own ideas about making viewers stop and think and subverting formalities of classicism, Monreal skillfully created an escape accessible to most people, aligning with Gucci's focus. We can see Monreal's idea behind blending elements like the influence of works by Hieronymus Bosch and Jan van Eyck with icons of Gucci's campaign that make the artwork relatable to a broad audience of all ages. Painting a beautifully clothed couple as the subject in the Jan van Eyck's The Arnolfini Marriage (1390-1441) and Gucci's iconography of the two headed swan, non proportionate grid of trees with oddly large fruits and strangely small characters in the place of icons in Bosch's Garden of Earthly Delights (1490-1510), Monreal makes his work surrealistic while connecting parallels with the works of old masters.

These art 'hallucinations' artworks for the Gucci campaign were the brainchild of Spanish artist Ignasi Monreal, who used his 'absolute freedom' by gucci to unleash his vivid visions into creating escapes that integrate the antique artworks with modern references.

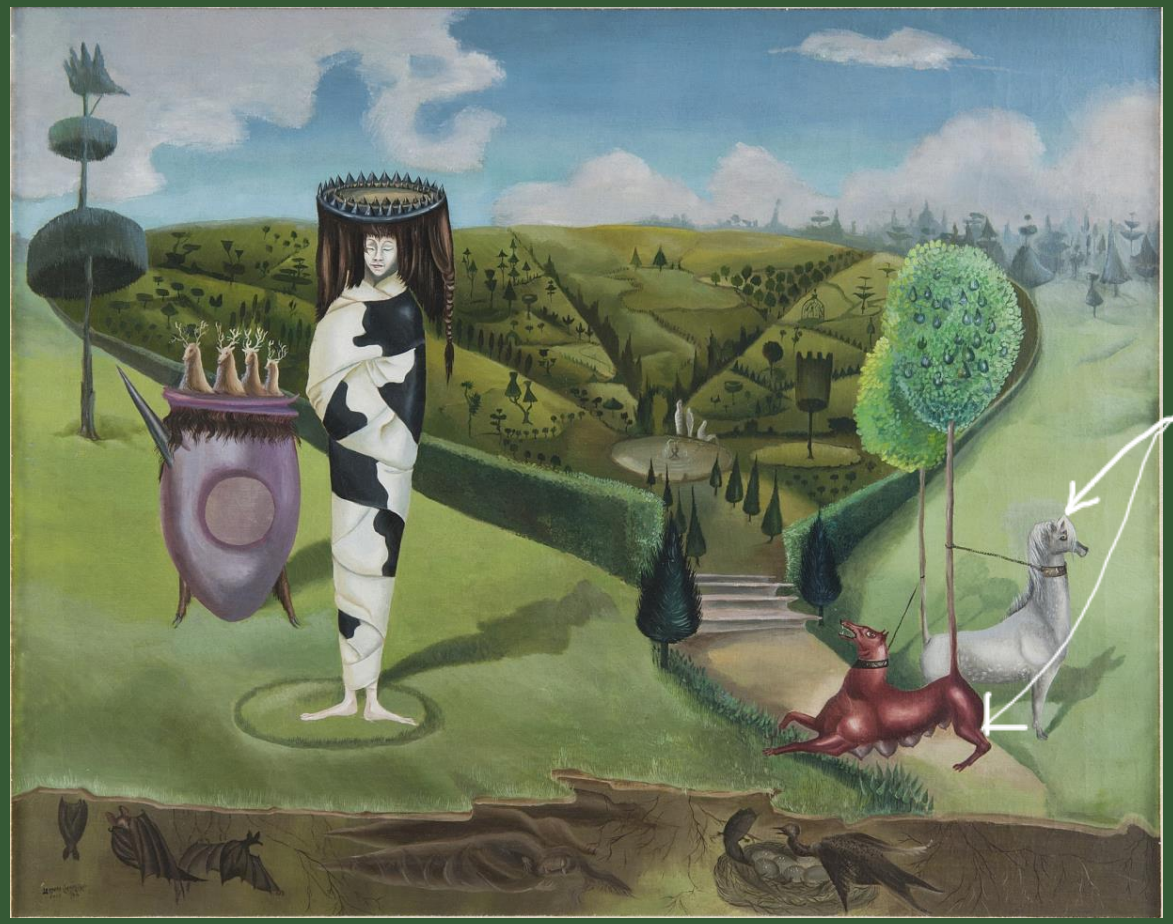


Bosch's Garden of Earthly Delights

Jan van Eyck's The Arnolfini Marriage



Conceptual and Contextual Analysis of ‘Green Tea’



Conceptual Analysis

Carrington created "The Oval Lady" in 1939, in which she narrates the story of Lucretia, a very tall young woman who is fighting a nasty and domineering father. In addition to having the ability to shift into a white horse, the young woman also possesses Tartar, her most prized item and rocking horse made of wood, who comes to life when she is around, as a friend. Tartar is destroyed by Lucretia's father in to punish her after she indulged in rebellious behaviour by transforming herself into a horse in order to feel free. Green Tea was painted by Leonora in 1942. (The Oval Lady) She returns to Lucretia in this painting, showing her enclosed in a circle in which she is bound and covered in a cowhide-like black and white material, with English meadows in the background, possibly as a symbol of longing for her country. A lactating dog and a little white horse, suggestive of her alter identity, are also bound together by their tails, which blend into a couple of trees.This intimate picture may allude to the artist's experiences while incarcerated at Santander's mental institution or her father's attempt to break her will.

Cultural Background

Leonora Carrington, a British-born artist, had a long and famous career that lasted seven decades, producing a wide range of paintings and sculptures that explored mystical themes. During the intensity and agony of interwar Europe, the artist developed her first Surrealist works. During World War II, she fled the continent and moved in Mexico City, where she helped to develop a thriving creative community and allowed her profession to flourish—she integrated regional mythology and Catholic iconography into her ideas of a fantasy, matriarchal world. Carrington appeared widely in locations such as Mexico City, New York, Tokyo, Los Angeles, Paris, and San Francisco throughout her lifetime.



Contextual Analysis

Leonora was raised in a luxury that was completely unknown to common labourers, such as those employed by her father's incredibly profitable chain of textile factories. The Carrington family comfortably lived at a level of splendour comparable to that of the majority of other debutantes in 1935. One of the keys of Leonora's character is that she lacked a sister with whom she might have related and instead had three brothers, whose independence she was constantly resentful of.

A day at the races was more thrilling for Leonora than getting ready for a ball or having tea, but females were not allowed to place their own bets or go to the paddock to see the horses before the race. In a fit of rage, Leonora pulled out a book, sat in a corner, and finished it. Her vociferous resistance disappointed her parents. She was acting as she would throughout her entire life and was not afraid to be herself. These influences of her experiences during her upbringing can be seen throughout this artwork in the well-trimmed and artistically styled trees, the cloaked oval lady, the typical luxurious British garden layout, and the wooden horse and lactating dog that arise from the things that impacted her most during her childhood. Her skewed depiction of fairly normal things that play with perspectives and include a dangerous underworld contribute to the surrealistic nature of this piece and give the audience an escape into her interpretation of her experiences almost as though the audience can step into her mind and see the images she perceives.

Conceptual and Contextual Analysis of ‘Dominus Aeris Escape 5’



Conceptual Analysis

Thukral and Tagra started this project by looking at the ideas of success. The artists narrowed down to the idea of migration, for this body of works, and how people choose certain decisions or areas to move ahead, and their entire families are also taken and attached with this change.

The idea behind their escape series was to narrate the stories of people who worshipped the moving abroad. They wrote approximately 9 of stories which they started illustrating as visual representations. They began to document their own friends in different towns as well as the houses, the changing architecture in India and everything from the style and food that is becoming more aligned to contemporary western norms.

One of the stories was of a girl who wanted to go to meet her husband in America and she tries many ways out of desperation. As someone comes from America in a hot air balloon, she wants to use it to get there. The hot air balloon is symbolic of her desire to fly. In this painting there are also other modes of transport such as flights and wheels which are used to further emphasize the main theme. They didn’t copyright the script as they want viewers to use it freely, making whatever they’d like to from it. Each story uses a different protagonist with the same theme of escaping or moving away.



Thukral and Tagra questioned themselves and their fellow artists, “What does an artist do in volatile situations?” Answering this, they used their artworks to share their beliefs about social issues and hope to create a change through simplifying their matter into immersive and playful works for viewers to learn from and comment on clearly.

Here, the use of bright colours, large intriguing subjects, along with relatable and fun icons in an engaging composition make the artwork accessible while entertaining for viewers while sharing their message.



Contextual Analysis

Jiten Thukral was born in Jalandhar, Punjab, in 1976, and got his BFA and MFA from Chandigarh College of Art and Delhi College of Art. Sumir Tagra was born in New Delhi in 1979 and obtained a BFA from the Delhi College of Art before going on to the National Institute of Design in Ahmedabad to further his education. Their fine training in the arts allow them to translate their ideas visually with effectiveness and use techniques of painting to bring out the surrealistic style with precision. They are also able to create interactive exhibitions and make complete use of the spaces their art occupies by not restricting themselves to mediums or canvases. Their common interest in games and sports can be seen throughout their body of work withing the smaller elements and iconography.

In 1984, when the Anti-Sikh riots happened in Punjab people began to move abroad due to safety concerns. But Thukral and Tagra noticed how by the 1990s, even when Punjab became completely secure, every family was already separated with at least one person abroad while the rest of the family was still waiting to leave India. The artists used this context to express their ideas about escapism. Due to their own experiences with their families wanting to go abroad, this issue was relevant in their lives. The flow with which the smaller hot air balloons are depicted highlight their opinions of these dreams of migration lacking rigidity and solid justification.

Artists' Responses to Cultural Stimuli



Ignasi Monreal

The combination of originality, inspiration from the works of old masters and representation of Gucci's brand resulted from a dilemma faced by Monreal - choosing to do projects for people under commission or express his own vision of the world.

The new world created by Ignasi Monreal combines the culture and tradition that he was brought up with as he mentioned in his interview with Nina Azzarello, designboom. Due to the freedom he felt while working with Gucci, he created historic 'hallucinations' by merging the tradition and culture from renaissance paintings with contemporary visuals relevant to Gucci while creating a message for a younger audience that connects them to an older audience. He hopes to enlighten a younger generation about the cultural significance of the historical works through Gucci's reach. The renaissance aspects that have been inculcated into Monreal's aesthetic sense since a young age can be seen in the composition and colour schemes including emerald green and renaissance gold that allude to Bosch's 'The Garden of Earthly Delights' as well as his allusion to the 'Arnolfini Portrait' in the subject of his artwork.

The Gucci visuals are the recurring themes and icons that distinguish the Gucci brand such as the snake on the bottom left, the red and green attire on the elephant, all the clothing and the Gucci logo itself.



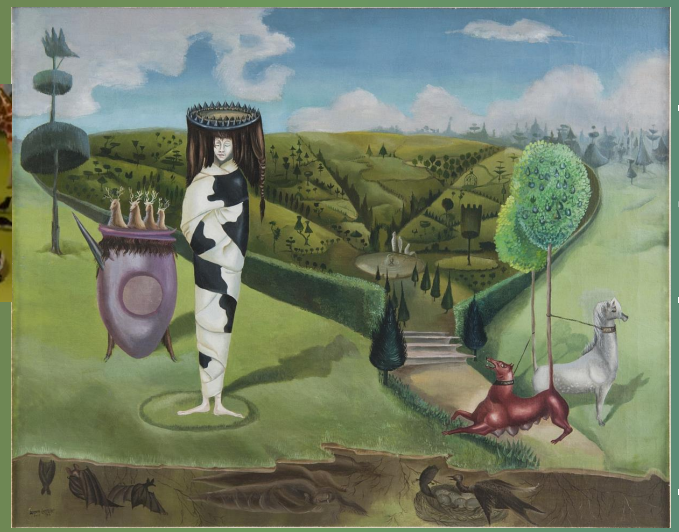
Ignasi believes that art can create a large impression on a person when it is aesthetically pleasing. This explains his multitude of references from his trips to Gucci offices in Milan and Rome where he used observances from his surroundings to add to his artworks. This is because of Ignasi's disapproval of modern culture where people instantly accept or decline photos while scrolling through social media without taking a second look at them.

Leonora Carrington

Leonora expresses her escape as a result of multiple events in her life which also led to her literal escape to Mexico from England. Even though Leonora's colours, line, textures, form and techniques used align to British fine art conventions(possibly due to the art she observed the most in the luxurious Victorian mansion where she was brought up), her surrealist compositions, subjects and perspectives reflect the impact of events in her life.

While the London season made girls feel secure in their place in British society, Leonora saw it for all its snobbery, narrowness and conventionality. She expresses this distinction of her opinion of what it truly was with the help of a contrasting underworld. Her use of multiple perspectives and planes throughout the painting agree with her rebellious nature and her desire to break conventions.

Since she was a young girl she loved horses but women were not allowed to go to the paddock to see the horses before they raced. The expectations for young women of upper-class pre-war Britain were still extremely limited. Leonora communicates her emotions by painting the horses tied to trees. This is the same narrative she followed as she painted what she saw around her, and how she felt. In the middle of this perfect, manicured English landscape, a young woman is mummified, bound in cow-patterned fabric, and unable to move. This alludes to Carrington's first trip seeing the mummies at the British Museum that had a profound effect on her as they deal with their belief that death was not the end of one's life but the beginning of another.





Thukral and Tagra

Thukral and Tagra discussed how India's media and consumer environments have become more eurocentric. They draw attention to how traditional Indian traditions, such as extended family living and arranged weddings, persist while other norms, such as elevating those who have lived overseas and are more "western," have emerged. With the aid of a short tale they wrote, this artwork depicts their response to this societal issue. Therefore, their decision to illustrate the components of westernised Indian culture using surrealism and realism reflects their appreciation of fine art. They effectively communicate their views on issues of life and death topics to a younger audience by using suitable colours, iconography and an interactive composition. The artistic methods used by Thukral and Tagra are lyrical and analytical. For the sake of expressing their opinions, learning more about themselves, and analysing a world that is always changing, they simplify complicated cultural issues into something that is understandable to a broad audience.

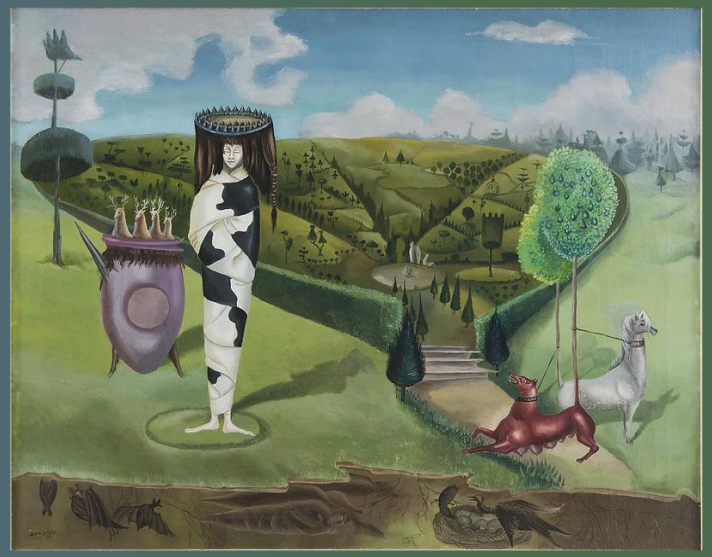
Comparison of '*Dominus Aeris Escape 5'* and '*Green Tea'*

Perspective

The use of perspective in both artworks bring about surrealism through the lack of depth in Thukral and Tagra's Dominus Aeris Escape 5 and distorted landscapes in Leonora Carrington's Green Tea.

Thukral and Tagra's painting excludes gravity and the technical aspects of flying hot air balloons, using a 2 dimensional background while Leonora's painting fuses different planes that add to the confusing nature of the piece.









Context

Even though both the artworks reflect migration, the approach differs by Thukral and Tagra's views on people in their lives leaving India for the dream they think awaits them in other countries while Leonora herself migrated to Mexico. Thukral and Tagra decided to study in India, unlike the Indians that inspired this artwork.

According to them, Indian culture is slowly being westernised as shown through the integration of rooftops in Indian architecture. Leonora Carrington escaped being shipped off to South Africa, as her parents had planned, she then divorced her husband and moved from New York to Mexico where she continued to live along with other European artists; her artwork displays the structures she saw while growing up in a luxurious British setting.

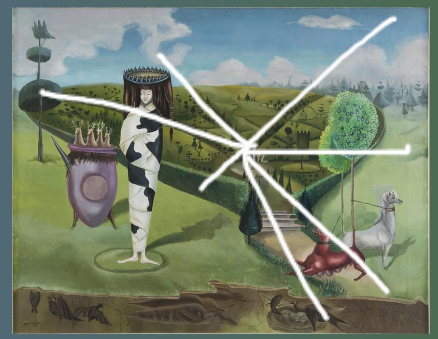
Formal (colours and imagery)

Thukral and Tagra approach this painting with playfulness and an image of optimism through the use of vibrant colours, contrasts between cool and warm colours and icons representing games while highlighting the westernisation of Indian culture through the Indian structures painted.

Leonora has a more personal approach - her use of neutral colours, an underworld and multiple perspectives shares her interpretation of the world as an unjust, distorted place with unusual structures and a filthy underworld.

Composition

The spiral composition in Escape 5 is contrasted with a radial layout in Green Tea. Both paintings use the central area to lay emphasis on the main theme of their artworks. While Leonora carries the audience to the boundaries of the artwork using a cityscape, an underworld, clouds and an intriguing tree, Thukral and Tagra carry the viewer's eyes across the painting by continuing to repeat their icons while maintaining a spirallic placement. They also use lighter, smaller elements like string lights, clouds and other images from games and nature to nudge viewers to observe the whole painting. On the other hand, Leonora maintains repetition only between the middle third of her painting, using a variety of imagery to interest the viewer.









Concept

Thukral and Tagra wrote a story of a woman waiting for her husband to return home and take her with him abroad, therefore creating a dreamy illusion using illustrative clouds to highlight the surrealism. Leonora Carrington, however, uses her take on creatures and elements in her surroundings to narrate the story of Lucretia, a young rebellious woman and relating it to her own life using the wooden rocking horses and surrealism using warped perspectives to portray her perception of the story.

Comparison of '*SS18* ***'hallucination"*** and '***Dominus Aeris Escape 5'***

Both of these paintings are symbolic of a progression; Thukral and Tagra's painting as a whole focuses on the movement of westernisation of Indian culture due to the false desire to go abroad while Ignasi Monreal's work highlights a horizontal transition of Eden to Earth to Hell.

Composition

The artworks effectively use multiple smaller sized icons to add variety and complexity to their pieces and to bring the audience to view the background of the artwork. This creates a sense of layers and contrasts the emphasis laid on larger icons. The layout with a large subject in the centre covering approximately a third of the composition is in the form of a spiral in Thukral and Tagra's piece while it's in the form of a horizontal thirds in Monreal's.

In both works the icon as the subject is repeated in different forms in the smaller icons.





Main subject

Smaller iterations











Sky

The sky has been treated differently - in Dominus Aeris Escape 5 the sky is depicted as a flat background to the hot air balloons ornamented with clouds in an illustrative style which adds to the surrealism of the piece and in Monreal's the sky is almost cloudless, adding perspective by the gradient of darker to lighter colours that creates depth and the smoke towards the right to create a sense of hell.

Colours

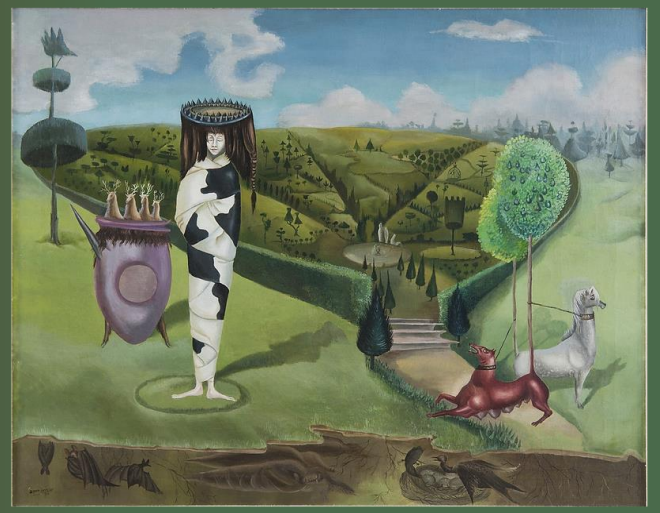
The central subject has an increased emphasis due to the use of contrasting colours; however, in Dominus Aeris Escape the complementary contrast with the background is between vibrant cool and warm colours which make the piece more playful and brings about feelings of excitement while in The Garden of Earthly Delights the contrast is between black and lighter colours which creates a yin yang with the background and the 'good' and 'bad' sides. This contrast along with the overall dull colours used allows Gucci's saturatedly depicted icons to stand out.

Overall, we can see the colour palette in Dominus Aeris Escape is far lighter and more vibrant than the sombre colours used in Monreal's Garden of Earthly Delights. This is unusual due to the mediums used - Thukral and Tagra used oil and acrylic on canvas and Ignasi Monreal used a digital platform.

Comparison of '*SS18 'hallucination"* and *'Green Tea'*

At first glance, both the artworks have a seemingly similar perspective. However, we see that in Leonora Carrington's work there are multiple perspectives woven in together creating a reflection of the distorted images in her mind.





Composition

Both pieces have a similar composition including a horizon dividing the sky from the green land. Both works depict seemingly calm gardens with a dark section. In Monreal's Garden of Earthly Delights, the 'hell' is a section towards the right when the painting is divided into thirds vertically, while in Carrington's Green Tea, the 'dark side' covers the lower fifth of the painting. The hell in Monreal's painting reflects the traditional idea of Eden and Hell as painted in the original Garden of Earthly Delights. The centre of Ignasi's work has depth in the background which is interrupted by a large subject in the foreground whereas Leonora's work creates depth through the combination of perspectives used which dominates her painting by keeping the foreground subjects away from the centre. The underworld of Carrington's work is a reflection of the odd creatures hidden beneath the surface in the story of Lucretia, mirroring the odd creatures she felt were hidden in her own life.

Texture

Through the texture, we can notice the mediums used in the paintings. Monreal's use of a digital medium provides smoothness in his work and the ability to detail small elements, whereas Carrington's use of oil paints also maintains smoothness, she also creates textures using the opacity of the paint as we can see in the grass and trees.

Inspiration

Ignasi Monreal drew inspiration from old renaissance paintings and his purpose included exposing younger generations to traditional dilemmas and values in today's context as his mother used to read Greek mythology to him instead of fairy tales. This is quite different from Leonora's inspiration drawn from her childhood. She loved horses, but as a girl was never allowed to bet or ride them. She also visited a mummy exhibit when she was younger which explains the strange white and black statue in the foreground of her work. Her depiction of a garden reflects how she was brought up in a luxurious Victorian household while the distortions in her painting represent her state of mind while being in a mental asylum.

Light

The treatment of light differs in the artworks. Monreal depicts a time before twilight when the sunlight seems to be fading away as seen in the gradient in the sky while Carrington shows light and a less obvious gradient in the sky with white clouds creating a sense of afternoon to evening hours.

Perspective

At the farthest point in the background, both artworks depict a city-like minute landscape. Monreal's landscape lacks details and ornaments - his uninterrupted sky - while Carrington's landscape includes multiple intricate forms using different shapes and soft clouds which carries the viewer's eyes to the background of the painting, unlike Ignasi's background.

Images and Colours

The icons used in Ignasi's Garden of Earthly delights include human figures and Gucci brand imagery which are large in the central subject and far smaller throughout the rest of the painting, depicted in vibrant, saturated colours to contrast the neutral colours of the background and to highlight Gucci's look. Leonora's icons include more surrealistic creatures like her horses, or the mummy. She also uses trees of unusual shapes and forms across her painting using multiple neutral shades of green to keep the emphasis on her foreground subjects.

The subjects in both the paintings show a contrast - The man and woman wearing black and light, warm coloured clothes in one artwork is different from the white and black, cow printed mummy in the other. This contrast serves to hold the viewer's attention in both paintings.

Applying McFee Framework to '***SS18 'hallucination"*** – Ignasi Monreal's take on the Garden of Earthly Delights

Audience's World

Extremely popular amongst millennials, Gucci's creative director, Alessandro Michele, led the brand in a millenial and teen-friendly direction by showcasing pop culture references and fresh designs. Monreal's vast global audience includes fashionable millennials who are often spotted with Gucci's iconic double G logo. Gucci being associated with celebrities, huge fortunes, and glamour lure is known for its luxury and sophistication is popular amongst a world of people who live up to such standards of culture.

Audience

To cater to an audience that is used to scrolling through media with speed that is conditioned to either consume or dismiss things immediately Monreal worked with the timeless quality of art using universal symbolism and realism to preserve its archeological role for future generations. To attract attention, he approached digital art combined with traditional art forms. He worked for brands to begin working with illustrators again, how it started, as compared to the major emphasis on photography and video.

Artwork

Monreal was commissioned by Gucci to reinterpret the House motifs and products in his own vision and media. He in turn used digital painting tools to render ironic portraits with pop culture references which are then printed onto essential Gucci silhouettes. Also, there are some famous artworks that anyone might recognise like Van Eyck's "Arnolfini Portrait", Bosch's "Garden of Earthly Delights"
Velázquez – "The things he did were so outrageous, but he was so good at it that they let him do whatever he wanted."

Artist

As a child, Monreal referred to himself as a "pretentious kid." After years of art classes, he moved into comics and then advertising and communications b to learn how to communicate visually, instead of just representing something. With access to applications like YouTube and InDesign, he was able to learn to edit using multiple software. Hence, the artist says he hopes to enlighten a younger generation about the cultural significance of the historical works.

Artist's World

Monreal's collection takes its primary inspiration from Old Masters paintings. "My mother used to tell me Greek myths instead of fairy-tales, so I believe they shaped my view of the world. I like to use the principles of classicism so I can subvert it after." Being a millennial, Monreal was familiar with the imagery of recently popularised imagery like unicorns and snow white and 'selfies.' Due to his strong cultural upbringing, he was able to make images from a mix of ones that exist—like Ophelia [by John Everett Millais]—and ones that he completely made up.

Applying McFee Framework to '*Green Tea*' – Leonora Carrington

Audience's World

During Leonora Carrington's life in Mexico, she saw the profound changes that World War II brought. Its basic economic structure was transformed, as to a lesser degree were its political, social, and cultural institutions. To offset wartime shortages, industrialization and urbanization were accelerated.

Audience

Not commonly known today within appreciators of Surrealist art, Leonora Carrington was a powerful force within and outside of the famous art movement. Even after her death, Carrington's work and ideas continue to resonate and expand their reach. In 2018, thanks to donations from Carrington's son Pablo Weisz Carrington, the Museo Leonora Carrington opened two venues in Mexico, where a collection of the Surrealist artist's art and personal belongings can be enjoyed. Most recently, in 2021, a newly discovered set of tarot illustrations by Leonora Carrington was published in a book, enchanting new audiences with its otherworldly illustrations in an iconic format.

Artwork

With the Nazi occupation of France in June 1940, Carrington fled south, where she suffered an emotional breakdown and was subsequently interned in a psychiatric hospital in the Spanish city of Santander. She recounted this traumatic event through writing, in her story Down Below, as well as visually. One of these works is Green Tea (1942), a painting Carrington completed during a brief period in New York City, where she escaped following her release from the Spanish hospital.

Artist

We can see references to her personal life through her depiction of wooden horses as horses were one of the great loves of Leonora's life. At a young age, Carrington's first trip seeing the mummies at the British Museum had a profound effect on her; 69 references to ancient Egyptian and Mesopotamian cultures are drawn on with more emphasis in her later work. She knew that her future would have nothing to do with being a member of the English upper class.

Artist's World

Until she had a French governess at home, and an education that was dominated by foreign languages and a knowledge of the arts. She was brought up in one of the wealthiest British families and was almost always surrounded by expectations set out for her. Throughout her youth, seeing the distinction in treatment between her and her brothers, she felt limited and acted rebelliously by reading books like Eyeless in Gaza by Aldous Huxley.

Applying McFee Framework to '***Dominus Aeris Escape 5'*** – Thukral and Tagra

Audience's World

Over the 2000s India has made its mark as one of the most vital and innovative centres of contemporary art. With great creativity and intellectual depth, a new generation of artists is reacting to the rapid changes typifying the globalised cities of the world's largest democracy. Indian contemporary art is a wide-ranging presentation of the new art of India with a whole array of related activities such as lecture evenings, educational processes for children and the young, and a festival programme of Indian films at the Copenhagen Film Festival. The project is associated with a research programme at ARKEN on contemporary art and migration, which resulted in a conference and a book, "Q".

Audience

International success and fame followed the duo everywhere, but T&T's art remained rooted in issues close to their home in Punjab. Increasingly artists like Thukral and Tagra are making works sensitive to issues rooted in the homeland but which speak a global language, where the personal becomes the political and social; therefore, making a change in the lives of their audience.

Artwork

This piece is from the "Q" exhibition and book which is the story of one of the many abandoned brides that haunt the state of Punjab, almost a contemporary fairy-tale fraught with loneliness, desperation, and confusion, yet infused with hopeful dreams that are difficult to let go of. The dreams of a new generation are described and social conflicts of the desire for Indians to leave India are exposed. All these issues revolve around Indian identity: how Indians themselves perceive their nation, how they interact within a global context in which they are gaining increased relevancy, how they change and adapt.

Artist

Jiten Thukral was born in 1976 in Jalandhar, Punjab. He earned his BFA from Government College of Arts, Chandigarh in 1998 and his MFA in 2000 at College of Art, Delhi.

Sumir Tagra was born in 1979 in New Delhi. He completed his BFA in 2002 from College of Art, Delhi and received his post-graduate degree at National Institute of Design, Ahmedabad.

T&T started their careers as graphic and product designers, their practice reflects the dynamism and ambition of India's rapidly growing economy. "We are influenced by the global nature of aesthetics and its prevalent existence; thus, we portray our fascinations through a distinctly Indian lens which results in a beautiful clash of sorts," says the dynamic duo.

Artist's World

In 1984, when the riots happened in Punjab people began to move abroad due to safety concerns but by the 1990s when Punjab became completely secure, every family already had one person abroad and the rest of the family was still waiting the go abroad, the people who had already grown up were waiting for the dream since the past 20 years and they were making their own problems in India as they weren't studying.

Conclusion – Elements of Surrealism in my Own Artwork



Formal - Inspired by the works of Thukral and Tagra, Leonora Carrington, and Ignasi Monreal, I inculcated surrealism into my own artwork. This has been done through the composition, perspective and interplay between colours and iconography. The lack of logic in the composition: the floating wine glasses and Ragu sauce, the intestines wrapped around the gumball on the truck, the tongue sticking out of a tire, and the fork poking in the bottle of Armagnac augment the painting's surrealistic aspects while expressing my opinions about the attitude towards meat consumption I've observed in my environment.



Concept - My piece is based on a poem I highly resonated with – 'A Healthy Meal' by Carol Ann Duffy, thus, the iconography that contributes to the surrealism of my work is derived from my visualization of imagery from the poem such as "secret dreams of innocent cows", "The menu lists the recent dead in French" and "the language of tongues is braised in Armagnac".Additionally, the illustrations of the truck and gumball originate from my opinions that meat consumption has a never-ending attitude towards it and the lengths to which people go to attain their meat.



Context - Being an English student, I came across this poem by Carol Ann Duffy after my English class. I myself became a vegetarian 2 years ago as I read about Pythagorous's theory linking meat consumption to the value of human life. Since then, I have noticed how large trucks in India are used to transport chickens which are then hung on display in butcher stalls which I depicted as a contrast to the freely flying birds.



In conclusion, I think the works of surrealism chosen have impacted me as an artist. Through this comparative study, I understood how surrealism is effective in creating an escape that can transport the audience to illogical scenes in an artist's mind without the limitations of reality.